

I AM NOT THE SUM OF MY PARTS

Contemporary healthcare often approaches the human body through separation; segmented into parts, zoomed in, and delegated to separate specialists. The work is informed by the Dutch concept of *verzuiling* (pillarisation), a phenomenon of societal, and thus informational, division that forms a lens through which the body comes to be seen as a collection of distinct systems rather than an interconnected whole. Looking through the lens of light microscopy, I examine how technologies of viewing shape the way we understand and relate to the body.

A selection of bodily tissues (adipose, muscle, and epidermal) is developed into a series of knitted structures. Each structure translates a specific bodily behaviour (cushioning, contraction, protection) into material form.

Developed through experimental knitting techniques at the TextileLab in Tilburg, these knitted structures transform microscopic imagery into tactile, human-scale encounters. Soft, touchable, and suggestive of bodily presence, they invite interaction rather than observation. Enlarged tissue structures become something to encounter rather than diagnose and, when reunited, reveal the body as a remarkable, collaborative system; one that is more than the sum of its parts.

The work creates space for play, touch, and wonder, reminiscent of the way children explore and learn about the world. I find this curiosity in sore need of reintroduction to those facing medical challenges. For this reason, I envision the installation in a children's hospital: a space where visitors can marvel at the totality of their body, rather than focus solely on the part perceived as "broken".